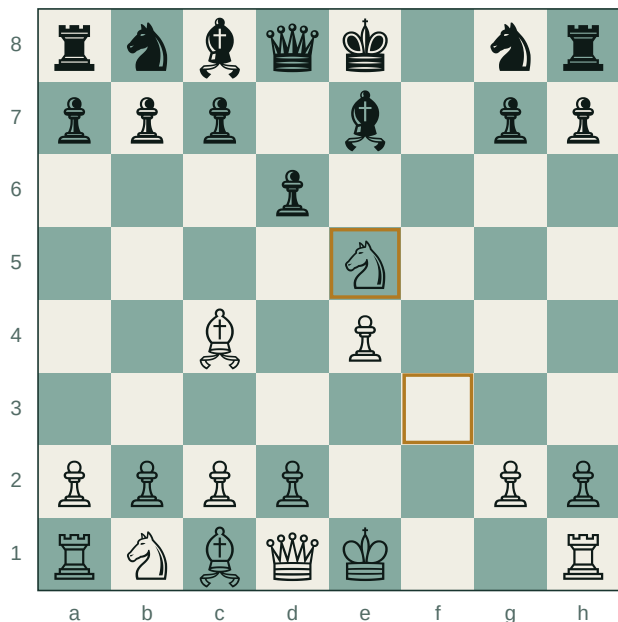


Loose-piece tactics: Black, move 6

Loose-piece tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 6.Nxe5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

6...dxe5 7. Qh5+ g6 8. Qxe5 Nf6

6...dxe5 The pawn captures the knight on e5. Recorded reply: **7.Qh5+**.

7...g6 The pawn moves from g7 to g6. Recorded reply: **8.Qxe5**.

8...Nf6 The knight moves from g8 to f6.

At the end, nominal material is White 35 / Black 36 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +2. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +2:** the balance goes from -1 to +1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on e1. Geometrically undefended: knight on e5 and rook on h1. Check for tactical protection.